WINOOSKI SCHOOLS

Nicole Mace <nimace@wsdvt.org>

11/4 Public Comment - Caitlin MacLeod-Bluver

Nicole Mace <nimace@wsdvt.org> Wed, Nov 4, 2026 at 2:01 PM
To: Nicole Mace <nimace@wsdvt.org>

11/4 Public Comment

My name is Caitlin MacLeod-Bluver. I am a resident of Moretown and a teacher at Winooski High School.

I spent almost a decade in Boston Public schools where our student population in the district is roughly the same size as the entire student population in Vermont. The benefits of larger districts are obvious to me, but I want to spend a few minutes reminding you of the strengths of the smaller, Winooski district. I know you will be hearing about these strengths in today's agenda--I want to share a few items that may not show up in traditional metrics.

First, working in a district that is PK through 12 in one building has obvious benefits. The collaboration across grade levels is a frequent part of our students' experience. Whether students are attending younger siblings' celebrations or performances, or sharing their own work, one building allows this work to happen seamlessly. Recently my highschoolers shared their poetry with 4th graders who were about to start a poetry unit; I start my science fiction unit with high school students reading to 2nd grader students; we recognize Black HIstory month with reading buddies each year; and we build mentoring opportunities for student students across grade level levels this could not happen in students or different buildings

Second, the size of Winooski district allows us to respond quickly to the needs of our students, both when we think about curriculum and larger district initiatives.

First, in terms of curriculum, we are able to quickly offer courses and experiences that meet the diverse needs of our students. In 2021, I started offering a course focused on the histories of the countries where many of our students come from. Students studied Somalia, DRC, and Bhutan,heard from experts in our community, and ultimately interviewed a family or community member and compiled these stories into a book and website we published. These are the types of learning experiences that we want for our students. Of course, this could happen in larger districts, but the red tape to make this happen can be prohibitive.

I know that there is a quest from the state to have larger high schools and I do know high school students that want a larger offering of classes. However, I do not want the benefits of a curriculum that adapts to the needs of the students in front of them to be lost.

Second, when we think about belonging, we all know that Winooski was the first and only School to adopt a Sanctuary School policy after the second Trump administration took office. Of course, we also know this policy served as the state model and is now state law. What you may not know is the pride that our students took in knowing that they went to a school that cared enough about them to take some risks. I have countless anecdotes about how meaningful this was for our student body.

Our small size also allows us to show our support for our diverse student population, whether it is cultural and religious and celebrations (such as funding our Community Iftar during Ramadan) or raising a country's flag to show solidarity and support with one of our communities.

As you begin your conversations today, please keep in mind the strengths of our small district, even the ones that may not show in your data. Thank you for your hard work.

On Thu, Oct 29, 2026 at 2:42 PM Caitlin MacLeod-Bluver <cmacleod-bluver@wsdvt.org> wrote:

Thank you.

Caitlin MacLeod-Bluver
2025 Vermont Teacher of the Year
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On Thu, Oct 29, 2026 at 12:02 PM Nicole Mace <nimace@wsdvt.org> wrote:

Hi Caitlin - the meeting is on Monday at 4pm. The committee will meet the first Monday of every month at 4pm. This one will be virtual - you can access the link on the agenda here.

Best,
Nicole

On Thu, Oct 29, 2026 at 9:26 AM Caitlin MacLeod-Bluver <cmacleod-bluver@wsdvt.org> wrote:

Hi Nicole
I watched the first merger mtg but honestly got lost and didn't write down when the nxt mtg was (and got confused where to even check online). Do you mind sharing with me?
Thank you!
Can't believe all you do! Another chair! We're lucky to have your leadership.

Caitlin

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